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INDIA TODAY was the first magazine to take opinion polls seriously in 1980 when we predicted Indira Gandhi would return to power after the disastrous Janata Party rule. Almost everyone else was expecting the opposite. Life was simple then. There was the Congress party and the rest. It was much easier to predict election results as one could measure the swing against the Congress. There was what came to be known as the TINA (There Is No Alternative) factor. Then, as the power of the Congress party weakened with the growth of regional parties, an Index of Opposition Unity (IOU) was developed. The higher the IOU the more Congress suffered. None of this applies any more.

Since 1989, no single party has managed to get a majority on its own and this in turn has meant a series of coalition governments, including the parliamentary miracle that was the Deve Gowda government where the ruling party had all of 46 MPs. It is this kind of scenario that makes opinion polling a very risky affair. Having said that, it is probably still the best way to take a call on today's messy election mêlée. And four Mood of the Nation polls that this magazine has done since the UPA came to power five years ago show just how messy it can get. In 2004, the Congress won just 145 seats but the hastily cobbled UPA with 234 seats and a 37.8 per cent vote-share came to power with outside support from the Left. The NDA came second best with a 33.4 per cent vote-share and 184 seats while the Third Front and 'Others' accounted for 28.7 per cent of the vote and 125 seats. Our latest poll shows the fortunes of the UPA and NDA have—minus some of their previous allies—nosedived to a 34.3 per cent vote-share and 200 seats for the UPA and a 29.9 per cent vote-share and 177 seats for the NDA. The gains belong entirely to the Third Front and 'Others' who are beneficiaries of a phenomenal 9.9 per cent positive swing that gives them an additional 43 seats over 2004. If anything, this proves that the electorate is divided as never before over regional and national issues as well as leaders.

The waning influence of the national parties signals the end of the dominant role that the UPA and the NDA had in the country's politics during the last few years. The situation is laden with delicious irony. Neither of the national parties can form a government according to this poll without the help of parties outside their fold. And none of the non-national parties can form a government without one of the national parties. As if that were not enough, some of the non-national parties are sworn enemies. For example, Jayalalithaa and Karunanidhi, and Mulayam Singh and Mayawati cannot be in the same government. This means a syndicate of regional leaders may well decide who will rule India and this could mean that the next prime minister may be completely disconnected from his party's actual electoral support. Our cover story this week looks at this bizarre bazaar for prime ministers which is likely to be set up after the elections. Editor Prabhu Chawla who has covered every election since 1980 writes that the 2009 elections will mark a significant departure in Indian politics. Or since the result is likely to be a dog's breakfast, it could be just a dress rehearsal for an election to follow soon after.

(Aroon Purie)



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